

Town of Westhampton
Town Hall
1 South Road
Westhampton, MA 01027

Finance Committee Meeting Minutes
Tuesday, March 17, 2015

The meeting convened at 6:30 PM

Present:

Finance Committee Members: Ellice Gonzalez, Jackie Brodeur, Mary Cleary, Tom Cleary, Jr., Maryanne Duggan, Aniko Giordano, Margaret Parsons, Joseph Pipczynski, Ed Zawacki.

Also present: Phil Dowling and Cheryl Provost for the duration of the meeting.

Additional visitors: Craig Jurgensen, HRSD Superintendent; Deane Bates, Westhampton Elementary School Principal; Cynthia Landers, HRSD Business Administrator; Roberta Jones, Assistant Business Administrator; and Westhampton Elementary School Committee Members Ashleigh Norris and Peter Cleary; David Blakesley, Highway Superintendent.

1. Vote to accept minutes of FinCom meeting of 1/13/15. Vote 9-0-0.
2. Correspondence: Beacon arrived. Received Municipal Financial Data brochure published by the Massachusetts Taxpayer Foundation and an invitation to the municipal conference to take place this Saturday, March 21.
3. Read proposed article regarding raising funds for the painting of town hall. Tabled the article as vote not required at this time.

Snow removal deficit spending. Voted 9-0-0 to approve deficit spending for snow removal.

Dates for next meetings: The March 24 meeting will begin at 6:45 pm. We will also meet on March 31, April 7 and April 14.

Town Caucus will be on April 13. Terms are up for Ed, Ellice and Margie. Margie stated that she will not be seeking reelection. If anybody has a person in mind that would like to run, they can be nominated at Town Caucus.

The town report will go to the printers on April 6. It will have the requested budget numbers. The FinCom's budget with voted recommendations will be printed on a separate handout to be distributed with the town report.

The Annual Town Meeting will be May 9 at 9:00am.

We noted that at Special Town Meeting last month the veteran's expenses were voted to be covered with free cash. FinCom had recommended that the expenses be covered with the money that has previously been earmarked for SCBA use. We noted that we could now use the SCBA money to help with the snow removal expenses.

4. Westhampton Elementary School Budget: Deane Bates presented the Westhampton Elementary School powerpoint and budget with additional input from Craig Jurgensen, Cynthia Landers, and Roberta Jones.

The Elementary School budget is a level-service budget that includes a requested 5.6% increase. The largest increases are due to the contractual salary increases and the anticipated hiring of two special education paraprofessionals.

The governor's budget currently calls for the elimination of the kindergarten grant program. If the governor's budget passes the house and senate, then we would not receive \$9,000 from the state for the kindergarten teacher.

Westhampton currently has 22% of its elementary population identified for special education. The state average is 16%.

Ellice noted that as a town we are bound to 2.5% increases and that funding a 5.6% increase is not realistic. Deane noted that there are few places where they can cut in their budget, but if they did not receive the requested amount they would look to cut non-essential programs or perhaps use school choice money to offset.

5. Highway Department: David Blakesley presented the Highway Department budget and the Transfer Station budget.

David has been working to fine tune the Transfer Station budget now that it has been under his jurisdiction for two years. He noted many areas where we can lower the proposed budget amount from the previous year.

The Highway Department budget includes a request for a new computer and a 2.5% increase across each category. We noted that the current budget spreadsheet had some computational errors. David will supply the corrected budget tomorrow.

We also reviewed the Highway Department salary requested increases as noted on the Selectboard budget. Previously the department employees received a \$0.50 per hour raise. In a letter to the Selectboard, they have requested \$0.60 per hour each year for three years to bring the increases closer to 2.5%. David Blakesley has requested a raise due to his increased responsibilities managing the Transfer Station. These requests are currently under review by the Selectboard.

6. Selectboard: Phil Dowling presented the Selectboard budget. We reviewed the increases for salaried employees and stipends. Margie noted that the Town Accountant's salary should be brought up to be in line with the Treasurer's and Tax Collector's salaries. The COA coordinator, Pat Miller, has requested more hours and thus an increase in salary. She will speak to us at next week's meeting. The Building Inspector has requested an increase of \$2,600 and has also requested an increase in the fee schedule for inspections (the fee increase would increase town revenue).

The proposed \$7,600 for IT includes funds for 5 hours/month of IT support with closer looks at our hardware for further recommendation for updates, support and server.

The counsel fees continue. We are close to expending \$30,000 to date. The lawsuits are expected to continue.

Next week we will meet with Council on Aging, Police and the Town Accountant.

The meeting adjourned at 9:15.

Respectfully Submitted by Mary Cleary